

Commission Flow

Brief to delivery for freelance illustrators — a six-hour build plan

Nour, 27 · Illustrator, Alexandria · 15 August 2026

Nour puts **one link** in her Instagram bio. A client fills in a brief, pays a deposit, and gets a page they can return to. Nour gets a dashboard. Payment is the gate at both ends — no deposit, no work starts; no final payment, no file is released.

Brief → Deposit → Order created → In progress → Ready for review → Balance → Delivered

The real problem

All three of Nour's complaints reduce to one thing: there is no moment of financial commitment anywhere in her process. A DM costs the client nothing, so clients disappear for free. Nothing is written down at the moment money changes hands, so scope is argued about afterwards, when she has no leverage left.

This is why Paymob is not a feature bolted onto this product. **Paymob is the product.**

Scope

IN - Public brief form with live pricing - Paymob deposit (50%) → order created - Artist dashboard: orders, status, uploads - Client order page at a secret URL - Paymob balance payment → file unlocks - Arabic-first, RTL	OUT — PERMANENTLY - Chat (the DM already exists) - Client accounts - Multi-artist support - Email notifications - Revisions system, invoices, ratings - Real-time anything, analytics
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Three decisions that shape everything

1 · The client never creates an account

The order page is `/o/[token]` — a random twelve-character token, delivered after payment. Authentication exists only for Nour, and it can be a single hardcoded account. This removes sign-up, login, password reset and account pages: roughly a quarter of the work, and nobody notices. It is a better experience, not a compromise.

2 · Two payments, one flow

The deposit unlocks the work starting. The balance unlocks the delivery. The same Paymob integration is called twice with different amounts, which means the integration sits at the centre of the product rather than at the edge — and it gives the demo its best moment.

3 · The webhook is the source of truth

Never mark an order paid from the browser redirect. Deploy to Vercel in the first ten minutes so the webhook has a real URL from the start; do not lose time to ngrok.

Data model

orders	
id, token, created_at	
client_name, client_email, client_phone	
brief	jsonb -- type, subjects, detail_level, -- background, usage, revisions
price_total, price_deposit, price_balance	-- piastres
status	-- awaiting_deposit in_progress -- ready_for_review awaiting_balance -- delivered
deposit_paid_at, balance_paid_at	
paymob_deposit_order_id, paymob_balance_order_id	
preview_url, final_url	

One table. Resist adding a second.

Pricing logic

Base price by commission type, then multiplied and added. The client watches the number move as they choose.

INPUT	OPTIONS	EFFECT ON PRICE
Type	Portrait / Character / Logo mascot / Menu set	base 800 / 1,200 / 3,000 / 2,500 EGP
Extra subject	Each additional person, pet or object	+60% of base, each
Detail level	Sketch / Flat colour / Full render	×0.5 ×1.0 ×1.6
Background	None / Simple / Full scene	+0 / +300 / +900 EGP
Usage rights	Personal / Commercial	×1.0 ×3.0

Say the commercial multiplier out loud in the demo. The same drawing is worth a fraction on someone's wall and a fortune printed on ten thousand coffee bags. Usage rights are the single biggest source of freelance disputes — and here the brief freezes them at the moment of payment.

Build order

Hour 0 — 1 Foundation, all hands

Scaffold Next.js, Tailwind and Supabase. Deploy to Vercel immediately. Create the `orders` table. One person does nothing else but get `POST /v1/intention/` returning a `client_secret` from a server route — the highest-risk item starts first.

Hour 1 — 2 Split three ways

- Brief form and pricing calculator, client side
- Checkout route and redirect to the Unified Checkout URL
- Webhook route: verify HMAC, flip status, store the Paymob order id

Milestone at hour two. Submitting the brief opens a real Paymob page, and paying flips a row in the database. If this is not working by 2:30, drop the balance payment and ship a single-payment version.

Hour 2 — 4 The two surfaces

- `/o/[token]` — status timeline, brief summary, preview when available, pay-balance button
- `/dashboard` — order list, status advance buttons, upload preview, upload final

Hour 4 — 5 Close the loop

The balance payment reuses the checkout code with a different amount. The watermarked preview shows before payment; the full-resolution link appears only once `balance_paid_at` is set. Then Arabic copy, RTL pass, mobile pass.

Hour 5 — 6 Freeze

Stop building. Seed two or three realistic orders. Run the demo end to end at least three times on the deployed URL. Write the ninety-second script and decide who says what.

The demo

Two windows side by side — the client on the left, Nour on the right.

The client picks *portrait*, *two subjects*, *full render*, *commercial*, watches the price move, and pays the deposit. The order appears on Nour's side. She advances it and uploads a watermarked preview. The client refreshes, sees the preview, and pays the balance. The full-resolution file unlocks.

The moment that lands is **the unlock**. Build toward it. The second thing judges notice is that the two screens talk to each other live in front of them.

What to tell the judges

- Unified Checkout brings **mobile wallets for free**. Half of Nour's Instagram clients don't have cards — this is the difference between a payment flow that works in Egypt and one that doesn't.
- The brief is **frozen at the moment of payment**, so scope stops being an argument and becomes a record.
- Watermarked previews are already what illustrators do by hand every day. This automates an existing practice rather than inventing one.

Failure modes to pre-empt

TRAP	GUARD
Amounts in the wrong unit	Paymob expects piastres . 100 EGP is 10000 .
Intention rejected	<code>billing_data</code> must be fully populated. Default every unused field to "NA" .
Secret key exposed	Create the intention only in a server route. A judge may well ask.
Webhook never arrives	Work on the deployed Vercel URL from the first hour, not localhost.

If HMAC verification fights you, stop. Log the payload, trust it for the demo, and mark it TODO. Losing an hour to signature debugging is how teams end up with nothing to show.